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Here's how you can edge your way into India's most wanted tech career

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If you've ever spent time in cities such as Bangalore, Hyderabad and Gurgaon, or, for that matter, any metropolitan city you'd probably appreciate how tough it is to turn a corner without bumping into an IT geek. And with their populations approaching obscene numbers, you won't be receiving respite anytime soon, especially if you join the brigade yourself!

The lure of the ever-growing Indian software industry is near-universal. Apart from being part of India's biggest industrial sector, you will be exposed to cutting-edge technology and will get paid a goodish bit more than your counterparts in other fields. However, you don't want to jump into it without knowing what it's all about, do you?

Getting In

Making your way into a software company has never been easier. With the industry growing at a

phenomenal pace, demand is high, and there just aren't enough IT professionals in this country. Some companies have even begun hiring students from non-IT backgrounds and training them for the role. Engineers and MCAs, though, still remain the cat's whiskers, and a good number of companies still hire only from that pool.

"Engineers, we find," says a senior HR executive from Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), "are better at conceptualising and reasoning, and usually do well in the long run. Of course, I wouldn't like to generalise." These sentiments are echoed by Rakesh Gupta, Director of Engineering at Impetus Technologies. "Engineering programmes help a student develop strong logical and analytical skills, and these, more than technical skills, make them desirable candidates."

So what do they look for when hiring fresh graduates? For starters, you need to have a good academic record. While a number of companies don't specify a cut-off, an aggregate of at least 60 per cent will ensure that you don't walk away from your campus notice board cursing under your breath. In addition, you will have to take an aptitude test, the format of which varies from company to company. TCS, for example, has separate tests for aptitude and personality. You will also need some basic programming skills to do well in these tests.

Once you clear the aptitude tests, it's time for the interview. Says Bharti Kakroo, HR Manager at Impetus Technologies, "We conduct two separate rounds of interviews—one to judge the technical knowledge of the candidate, and another to judge his or her personality."

I'm In! Now What?

Once you've been selected by a company, your training begins. Training typically lasts three to four months, and will cover all the fundamentals you need—programming and database concepts, developing algorithms and so on—before you are trained on a specific platform such as Java or .NET. Non-computer engineers needn't worry—companies have standardised training programmes that take this into account, and by the end of your training, you're going to be just as well-placed technically as the rest of your batch.

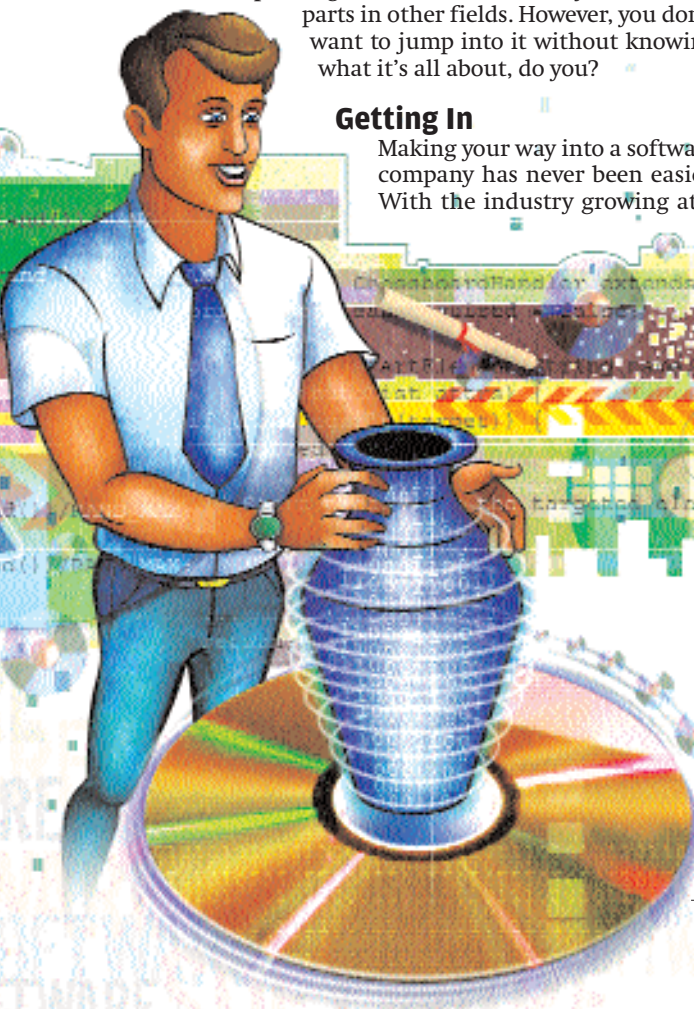


Illustration Chaitanya Surpur